

Technical Circular 04/26
Schedule of Exempted Floor Areas and Conditions of Grant
Issued 3 February 2026

1. Purpose

This circular sets out the categories of floor area that may be excluded from the calculation of gross floor area on a submission, the basis on which each exclusion is measured, and the conditions attached to each grant. It replaces Technical Circular 11/22 in full.

2. Basis of assessment

A claim for exclusion shall be made on the area schedule accompanying the general building plans, and shall identify each feature by the category and item number used in Table 1. A claim made after the plans have been approved shall be treated as an amendment and shall attract a fresh assessment fee. The applicant shall mark on the submitted plans the extent of every feature for which an exclusion is claimed, using a distinct hatching for each category, and shall provide a summary sheet reconciling the hatched areas against the figures entered on the area schedule. Where the development is to be constructed in phases, the schedule shall state the phase in which each feature falls, and the limits in Table 1 shall be applied to the development as a whole rather than to the individual phase. Discrepancies between the plans and the schedule shall be resolved in favour of the smaller area.

An exclusion is assessed on the area enclosed by the finished internal faces of the enclosing walls, measured at each floor level at which the feature occurs. Where a feature occupies more than one floor level, the area at each level is counted separately, and the aggregate is compared against the limit stated in Table 1 for that category. Where a feature is bounded on one or more sides by a structural column rather than a wall, the measurement is taken to the outer face of the column, except where the column is shared with an adjoining feature that is itself the subject of a separate claim, in which case the centre line of the shared column is used. An exclusion granted under one category may not be claimed a second time under another category, and where a feature could reasonably fall within two categories the assessing officer shall apply the category carrying the lower limit. The aggregate of all exclusions granted under Part B of Table 1 shall not in any event exceed ten per cent of the total gross floor area of the development, and the applicant shall demonstrate compliance with that aggregate cap on the area schedule submitted with the application. Where the applicant has previously obtained an exclusion for the same feature under a lapsed approval, the earlier grant confers no entitlement, and the claim shall be assessed afresh against the limits current at the date of the later submission. An assessing officer may require a site inspection before an exclusion under Part B is confirmed, and may withdraw a grant where the feature as constructed departs from the approved area schedule by more than five per cent. The measurement conventions in this section apply equally to a feature that is partly enclosed and partly open, and in such a case the area is taken to the line of the enclosing structure on the enclosed side and to the outermost edge of the roof or canopy on the open side. Where a canopy oversails a boundary, the area beyond the boundary is disregarded. The assessing officer shall record the basis of measurement adopted for each feature in the assessment record, and shall state in writing the reason for adopting the centre line convention wherever it has been applied. That record forms

part of the approval file and shall be produced on request when a subsequent amendment is assessed, so that the conventions applied to a development remain consistent throughout its approval history.

3. Schedule of exclusions

Table 1 lists each category of exclusion. The conditions referenced in the final column are set out in Section 4.

Category	Item	Basis of exclusion	Limit
Part A: Mandatory features			
A. Statutory provision	Refuse storage and material recovery chamber (1)	Full floor area	No limit
	Lift machine room, lift overrun and associated ventilation plenum (2)	Full floor area	No limit
	Refuge floor and the staircase serving it	Full floor area	No limit
	Pipe duct and vertical riser serving a mandatory plant room (3)	Full floor area	No limit
Part B: Green and amenity features			
B. Building services	Plant room for environmentally friendly building services (4)	Full floor area	5 per cent
	Plant room for rainwater harvesting and grey water recycling (5)	Full floor area	2 per cent
	Battery room serving photovoltaic panels (5)	Full floor area	2 per cent
C. Communal amenity	Covered landscaped area open on at least two sides	Full floor area	3 per cent
	Communal sky garden and the covered walkway serving it (6)	Full floor area	3 per cent
	Residents' clubhouse and ancillary changing rooms	Full floor area	3 per cent
Part C: Non-domestic development			
D. Headroom and void	High headroom and void in front of a cinema screen (7)	Void area at each level	4 per cent
	Void over an atrium serving a retail podium	Void area at each level	4 per cent
	Loading and unloading bay with headroom exceeding 4.5 m (8)	Area above 4.5 m	4 per cent
E. Back of house	Central refuse compaction room serving the whole development	Full floor area	No limit
	Goods lift lobby serving a back of house corridor (8)	Full floor area	1 per cent
Part D: Industrial and institutional development			

Category	Item	Basis of exclusion	Limit
F. Operational areas	Fireman's lift lobby and the smoke lobby serving it (9)	Full floor area	No limit
	Transformer room and switch room let to a utility undertaking (10)	Full floor area	1 per cent
	Covered vehicular ramp serving a basement car park	Ramp area on plan	2 per cent
G. Storage and collection	Bicycle parking area provided at ground level	Full floor area	1 per cent
	Recyclables collection point serving an institutional block (10)	Full floor area	1 per cent

4. Notes

Note (1) : The exclusion applies only where the chamber is provided at ground level and is accessible directly from a service lane or an off-street loading area.

Note (2) : The exclusion includes the lift machine room, the lift overrun and the associated ventilation plenum, but excludes any part of the enclosure that is used for storage or that houses equipment unrelated to the lift installation.

Note (3) : A pipe duct qualifies where it serves rainwater drainage, soil and waste disposal, or forms part of the distribution network of a mandatory plant room. A duct serving a single tenanted unit does not qualify.

Note (4) : The plant rooms exempted under this item are the hot water boiler room, the filtration plant room serving a swimming pool, and the satellite master antenna television room.

Note (5) : The exclusion is granted only where the harvested or recycled water is reticulated to at least two separate end uses within the development, and where the battery room is separated from occupied accommodation by a fire barrier of not less than two hours.

Note (6) : The sky garden shall be open to the sky over at least half its area and shall be accessible to all residents without charge. A walkway qualifies only where it is the sole means of access to the garden.

Note (7) : High headroom and void includes the void in front of a cinema screen, a theatre balcony, a banking hall, a shopping arcade, an auditorium and a sports hall.

Note (8) : Where the headroom exceeds 4.5 m only over part of the bay, the exclusion is limited to that part, measured on plan.

Note (9) : The smoke lobby qualifies only where it is provided in accordance with the code of practice for fire safety and is not used for any other purpose. A lobby that also serves a passenger lift does not qualify.

Note (10) : The exclusion applies only where the room is handed over to the utility undertaking or to the management body on completion, and where no part of it is let for commercial storage.

5. Assessment procedure

The sequence in Figure 1 shall be followed when an exclusion is claimed.

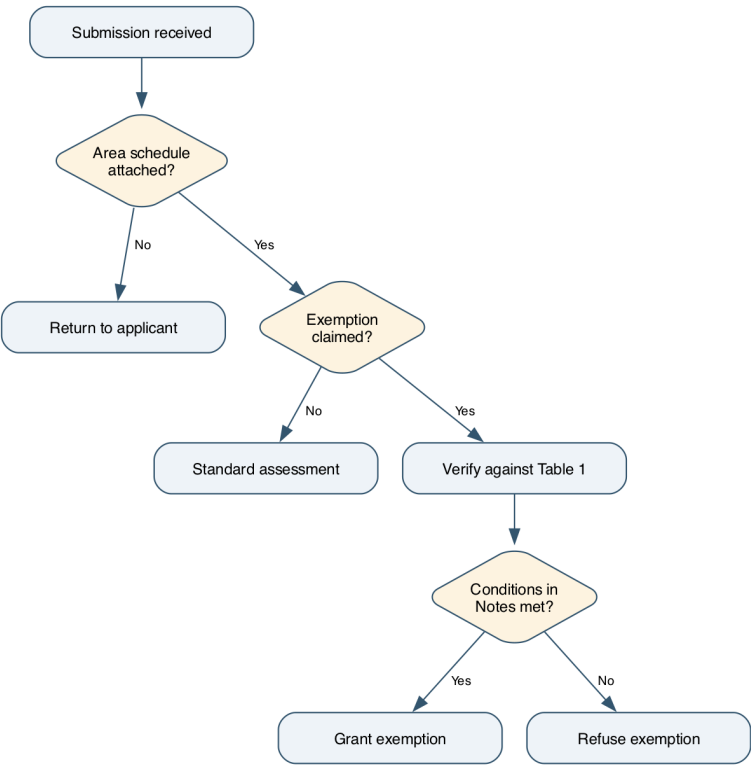


Figure 1. Assessment sequence for a claimed exclusion.